MONDAY
OCTOBER 26, 2026
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UAE Presidential Court

UAE, BENIN PRESIDENTS DISCUSS WAYS TO STRENGTHEN TIES

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan and Romuald Wadagni, President of Benin, discussed ways to enhance bilateral ties, with a focus on the economic and investment fields, in Abu Dhabi yesterday. The two sides affirmed their commitment to deepening bilateral relations and exploring further opportunities for cooperation, particularly in renewable energy, agriculture, infrastructure and food security. The leaders also witnessed the exchange of the UAE-Benin Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement.

Saudi Arabia downs wave of Houthi missiles

MAKKAH, MADINAH SANCTITY CALLED A RED LINE AS RIYADH AIRPORT OPENS

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Saudi Arabia intercepted a barrage of Houthi missiles and drones yesterday as explosions rocked Riyadh and security alerts spread across southern cities, even as the capital's international airport reopened after a two-week shutdown.

The Saudi-led coalition said it intercepted and destroyed 10 ballistic missiles targeting the kingdom's southern region, along with a cruise missile aimed at Khamis Mushait.

Air defences also downed a ballistic missile and two drones near Riyadh, where AFP journalists reported hearing three explosions early yesterday.

Residents received emergency alerts warning of hostile aerial threats, while warnings were issued in Abha, Taif, Namas and Jazan.

In Khamis Mushait and Ahad Rafidah, falling debris from intercepted missiles injured a Saudi citizen and an Asian resident, the Saudi Press Agency reported. Three residential buildings and seven vehicles were damaged.

The Houthis claimed attacks on three Saudi airports, energy installations, a pipeline and an air base.

Sheikh Abdulrahman Al Sudais, head of religious affairs at the Grand Mosque in Makkah and the Prophet's Mosque in Madinah, warned that the security and sanctity of Islam's two holiest mosques were a "red line" that must not be breached. His warning followed reports of intercepted Houthi missiles and falling debris in the two regions, although the Houthis denied targeting the holy cities.

UAE condemns attacks

The UAE strongly condemned the Houthi attacks, describing them as a violation of the kingdom's sovereignty and a threat to its security and stability.

Despite the continuing attacks, King Khalid International Airport resumed limited operations yesterday following a two-week closure.

Airport authorities said Terminal 1 would handle domestic flights, while Terminal 2 would serve international flights operated by national carriers.

Houthi spokesman Yahya Saree warned that the airport remained "unsafe" and a "military target".

The escalation comes amid heightened US concerns over Iran. A Friday intelligence memorandum warned that Iranian plots targeting Americans had reached advanced stages, Axios reported.

SEE ALSO P6

RTA to open final Trade Centre Roundabout bridge on Friday

Journey time on key road to drop from 6 minutes to one

DUBAI

BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

The traffic at one of the busiest intersections in Dubai is set to ease up dramatically from this Friday as the Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) opens the final bridge of the mega Dh696 million World Trade Centre Roundabout Development Project.

The 1,000-metre, two-lane bridge will accommodate approximately 3,000 vehicles per hour, serving traffic from Al Majlis Street towards 2nd December Street.

The journey from Al Majlis Street to 2nd December Street will drop from six minutes to one minute, while the average waiting delay at the intersection will fall from 12 minutes to just 90 seconds.

With the opening of this new bridge, RTA will have completed all major works under the project, which include five bridges with a combined length of 5km. Mattar Al Tayer, Director General and Chairman of the Board of Executive Directors of RTA, said the project will increase road network capacity to keep pace with Dubai's rapid growth, reinforce its global leadership in business, and enhance quality of life.

Al Tayer explained that the development complements Al Mustaqbal Street Development Project, where work is progressing rapidly to expand the street to four lanes in each direction.

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Etihad launches first direct Gulf flight to Calgary

Water-cannon salute welcomes sold-out historic flight

ABU DHABI

BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

This landmark connection makes Calgary Etihad's second Canadian destination, and represents the first direct flight from any Gulf city to the Alberta province.

Etihad Airways has made history by launching the first-ever non-stop flight between Abu Dhabi and Calgary, establishing a direct air corridor between the Gulf region and Western Canada.

The inaugural, sold-out flight, EY29, touched down at Calgary International Airport yesterday where it was welcomed with a traditional water-cannon salute. This landmark connection makes Calgary Etihad's second Canadian destination, complementing its established Toronto service, and represents the first direct flight from any Gulf city to the Alberta province.

Operating four times a week on Tuesdays, Thursdays, Saturdays, and Sundays, the route utilises Etihad's Boeing 787-9 Dreamliner. The non-stop service completely eliminates the need for previous time-consuming connections, offering business and leisure travelers vastly faster transit times.

Seamless gateway

For UAE residents, it opens a seamless gateway to the Canadian Rockies, Banff, and Jasper national parks.

For passengers travelling from Calgary, the new service provides direct access to Abu Dhabi, along with onward connections to destinations across the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries, Africa India, Pakistan and other countries in Asia.

Airline officials confirmed plans to scale the frequency to a daily service subject to market demand.

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